tucked it to the side of the coach in which he was protesting. It was sad to see how an outstanding officer of merit with thirty-four years of glorious service was dismissed overnight. It left the nation and the country's bureaucracy in shock. [13 8]

'MONDAY AFTERNOON MASSACRE' AT RAIL BHAVAN

This story is about a head-on collision, not with trains, but between the Railway Minister and the Railway Board Chief. The then Railway Minister A.B.A. Ghani Khan Choudhury (Railway Minister from 2 September 1982 to 31 December 1984) was at constant loggerheads with the Railway Board Chief, Mohinder Singh Gujral, an officer of the Indian Railway Traffic Service. Gujral, a no-nonsense tough officer, had been a star, and overturned the fortunes of the railways in his short stint. He had been personally picked by Prime Minister Indira Gandhi to steer the sinking ship of the Indian Railways two years earlier in 1980, catapulted to the post of Chairman, Railway Board and Member Traffic, and Principal Secretary, Ministry of Railways, with an extension in service beyond superannuation. [139]

Choudhury was a temperamental man, and when his appointment as Railway Minister was announced in September, many railway officials saw red. But Gujral went ahead full steam with the same drive that had helped him bring about a dramatic improvement in railway performance since he took charge in November 1980. Choudhury was soon issuing a series of orders that the officials frequently found impossible to carry out, and the minister responded by roundly condemning the railways at internal meetings and elsewhere. The atmosphere was quickly charged with tension as acid file notings went back and forth. 'Don't treat me like a child,' Choudhury is reported to have once told Gujral. [140] The tensions escalated and Choudhury shunted Gujral into retirement.

This is an example of how powerful governments can be. No civil servant has won a battle with a minister. And given the open war between Railway Minister A.B.A. Ghani Khan Choudhury and Railway Board Chairman Mohinder Singh Gujral, it was only a matter of time before Gujral finally went as he did in what railwaymen are beginning to call the 'Monday afternoon massacre'.

Shunted into retirement, siding along with Gujral was his fellow board member and someone who might have been his successor, B.B. Lal. With a